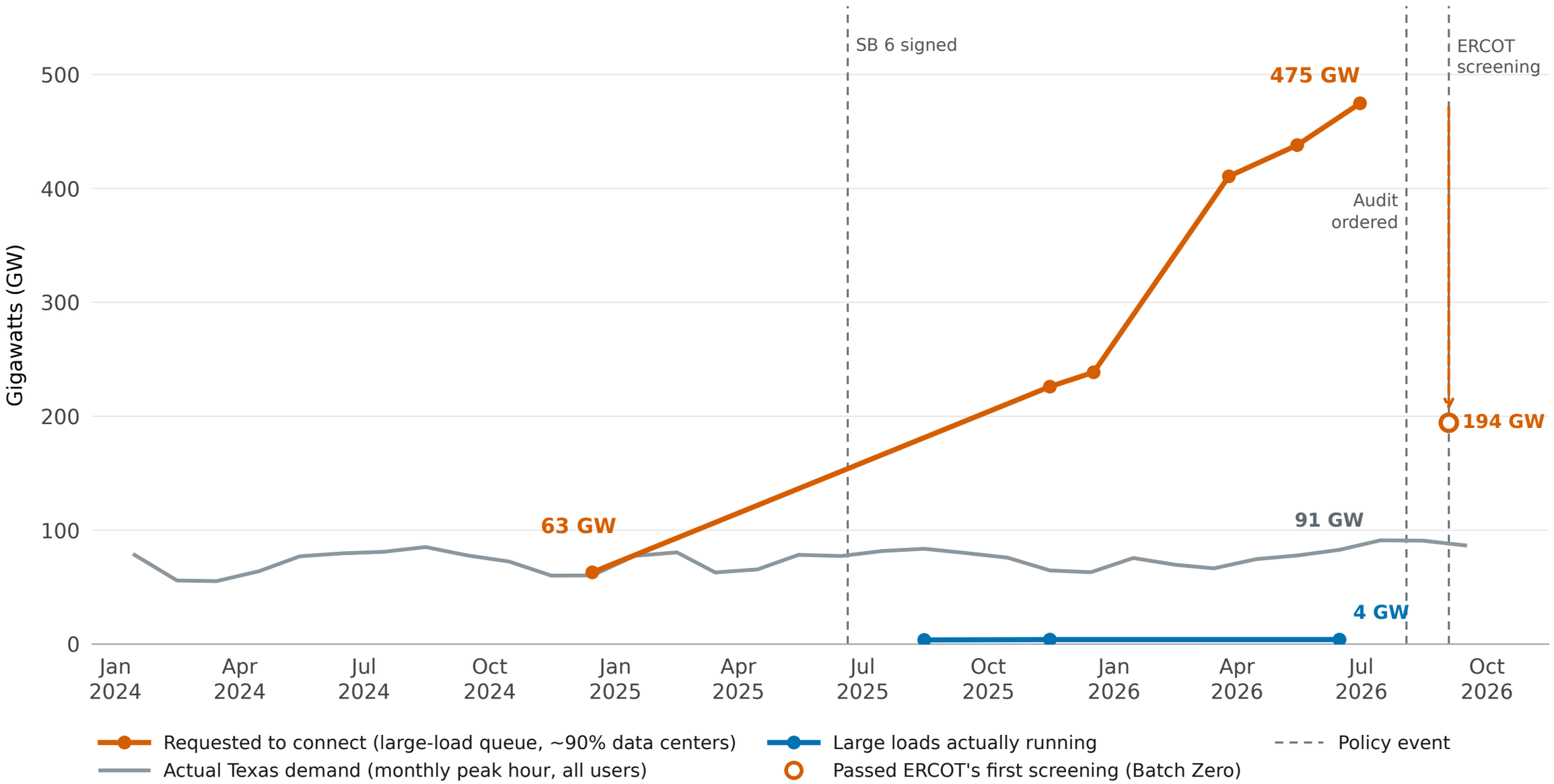
Figure 1. Texas data-center power requests exploded; actual demand barely moved



Takeaway: Requests to connect large loads (about 90% data centers) rose from 63 GW to 475 GW in 18 months, 5× Texas's record peak. Actual peak demand rose only from 85 to 91 GW (2024–2026), and large loads actually running stayed near 4 GW. Much of the queue is "phantom" load.

Data sources: ERCOT (Texas grid operator). Actual demand: ERCOT Hourly Load Data Archive, native load, 32,855 hourly readings (Jan 2023 – Sep 2026), monthly peak hour. Requested load: ERCOT board and Texas Senate presentations (Dec 2025 – Jun 2026); Dec 2024 and Nov 2025 values as reported by Latitude Media citing ERCOT. Load actually running: ERCOT monthly operational reports (observed monthly peak of approved large loads, all types). Screening: ERCOT Batch Zero update (Sep 2026). Events: Texas SB 6 (Mayer Brown); governor's audit order (POWER Magazine).